

On The World Tourism Map

Given the picturesque nature of the landscape, it is unsurprising that as far as tourism is concerned, the sky's the limit for Sikkim. A land of dramatic contours, it has rugged mountains, deep valleys and dense forests consorting with raging rivers, lakes and waterfalls to create a visual feast. The land is dotted with lakes, hot springs and holy caves, but the crowning glory of Sikkim is Mt. Khangchendzonga, the third highest mountain in the world.

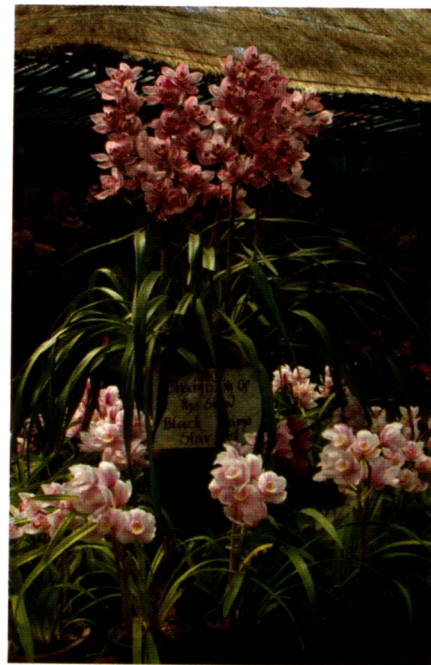
The SDF government, by putting tourism in the category of industry, has opened unlimited opportunities and is promoting the tourism sector as a new profession for the Sikkimese people, one that will allow them to move away from traditional occupations and fully exploit the potential of this new industry, thus creating more job opportunities for educated and literate Sikkimese citizens.

To make tourism as people-centric as possible the state government is promoting the concept of village tourism – where all villages will become a tourist destination so that the visitor to the state can experience the culture and traditional life of Sikkim's villages amidst great natural beauty. For tourism development "Tourism Master Plan" has been developed on the committed principle of eco-tourism and nature tourism with strict measures. In urban and semi-urban areas the concept of Urban Forestry, Eco-cities & Eco-villages has been developed. New concepts like Van Vas – construction of eco-friendly huts in lush green forests so as to make forests productive without harming them are being implemented.



- » Increase in foreign and domestic tourist has been nearly 20 per cent
- » Tourist spots are well publicised in India and abroad
- » A resolution has declared Sikkim to be an eco-friendly state
- » Tourist centres have been developed in each constituency

The state is encouraging adventure sports, rafting, trekking and rock climbing. Sikkim is also part of the ASEAN Car Rally and the Mountain Bike Rally. Facilities for paragliding are also provided. Tourist spots are being developed throughout the state apart from other innovative attractions. Installation of Skywalk at 10,000 feet, like that of Grand Canyon in Arizona, USA is being planned as well as ropeways to connect all important tourist destinations. No effort is being spared to make Sikkim the premier tourist destination in the country.



Empowering women, politically and economically

Sikkim can be justifiably proud of its record in empowering women, especially when compared with the rest of the country. After assuming power in 1994, the SDF government has taken several steps to help women who have been socially, politically and economically underprivileged over several generations. The first indicative development came about in the appointment of the first women Cabinet Minister in 1995 followed by other dedicated policy initiatives. Today, the efforts have borne fruit: women are at par in every sphere with their male counterparts and enjoy equal social status and political and economic rights. There are over 40 percent women in the state's policy-making bodies with women outnumbering men in the teaching occupation. Gender related violence

is a rarity. As in many other areas, Sikkim is an example to the nation in this regard. There is a plethora of facilities for women in Sikkim. The Government has made 40 percent reservation in Panchayati Raj for women and 30 percent reservation in Government employment. Widows get a generous state grant under the widow remarriage scheme; an excellent maternity benefit scheme is in place; rural women get free LPG connections and all benefits are provided in the name of the mother. Various government sponsored schemes have ensured increased educational and other facilities for the girl child, widows and working women for their comprehensive socio-economic progress. Children are given pre-school education along with regular health and hygiene care.

The State Government has also constituted the State Commission for Protection of Child Rights. Educational incentives for the girl child including Prema Yojana and other scholarship benefits are being initiated by the Government. The State Government has ensured an affirmative share to the womenfolk in all spheres of socio-economic and political development. Facilitated by increased awareness and provision for women reservation, women participation in the recently concluded Panchayat Elections has been very impressive and overwhelming. In the total of 950 plus seats, women have won almost 400 seats (inclusive of both Gram Panchayat and Zilla Lanchayat) recording a strong presence ever in the local bodies.